

Anthropology

Chapter 05

Society:

A large group of people who live together in an organized way and share culture, laws, values, and institutions.

Example: Bangladeshi society.

Group

A small or large number of people who interact with each other and share a common interest, goal, or identity.

Example: A study group or football team.

Community

A group of people living in the same area or sharing common interests, culture, or identity.

Example: A village community or online gaming community.

Structure

The organized arrangement or pattern of relationships and parts within a society or organization.

Example: Family structure or social structure.

Organizations

Formal groups created to achieve specific goals through coordinated activities.

Example: Schools, NGOs, banks, or companies.

System

A set of connected parts that work together as a whole.

Example: Education system or political system.

Status

A person's social position or rank in society.

Example: Teacher, student, doctor, or parent.

Role

The expected behavior, duties, and responsibilities connected to a particular status.

Example: A teacher's role is to educate students.

Diaspora

People from one country or culture living outside their homeland but maintaining connections with it.

Example: The Bangladeshi diaspora in the UK.

Social Network

The web of relationships and connections among individuals or groups.

Example: Friends, relatives, coworkers, and online contacts.

Social Capital

The benefits people gain through trust, cooperation, and social relationships within a network or community.

Example: Getting a job through a friend's recommendation.

Culture, Anthropology, and Islam

Culture, anthropology, and Islam are closely connected in understanding human life, society, and behavior. Anthropology is the study of humans, their cultures, traditions, beliefs, and social systems. Culture refers to the shared way of life of a group of people, including language, customs, food, dress, religion, values, and traditions. Islam, as a major world religion, strongly influences the culture and social life of millions of people around the world.

In anthropology, culture is considered learned behavior that is passed from one generation to another. People are not born with culture; they learn it through family, education, religion, and society. Cultural anthropology studies how people live, think, organize society, and practice traditions in different parts of the world. Anthropologists observe similarities and differences among human societies to understand human diversity.

Islam plays an important role in shaping culture in many Muslim societies. Islamic teachings influence daily life, social relationships, law, ethics, dress, food habits, marriage, and festivals. For example, Muslims pray five times a day, observe fasting during Ramadan, and celebrate Eid al-Fitr and Eid al-Adha. These religious practices become part of cultural traditions in Muslim communities.

Anthropologists study Islam not only as a religion but also as a cultural system. They examine how Islamic beliefs are practiced differently in various countries and societies. Although Muslims share common religious principles based on the Qur'an and the teachings of Prophet Muhammad, local cultures influence how traditions are expressed. For example, Muslim wedding ceremonies, clothing styles, and food customs may differ between Bangladesh, Indonesia, Turkey, and Saudi Arabia.

Islam also emphasizes social values that are important in anthropology, such as family unity, charity, justice, cooperation, and respect for elders. The Islamic concept of the Ummah refers to the global Muslim community united by faith. This idea creates strong social bonds among Muslims across different cultures and nations.

Cultural anthropology helps us understand that Islam is practiced within diverse cultural environments. At the same time, Islam influences culture by guiding moral behavior and social organization. Therefore, the relationship between culture, anthropology, and Islam shows how religion and society shape human life together.

In conclusion, anthropology studies human culture and society, while Islam provides religious and moral guidance that influences many cultures around the world. Understanding their relationship helps promote respect, knowledge, and appreciation of cultural diversity among people.

Chapter 06

An egalitarian society is a society where all people are considered equal and have the same rights, opportunities, and social status. It aims to reduce inequalities based on wealth, gender, race, religion, or class.

Short Notes on Egalitarian Society

- Promotes equality and fairness among all citizens.
- Supports equal access to education, healthcare, jobs, and justice.
- Opposes discrimination and social privilege.
- Encourages equal political and economic participation.
- Believes that no group should dominate or exploit others.
- Often associated with democracy, human rights, and social justice.

Features

- Equal rights for men and women
- Equal opportunities in employment and education
- Fair distribution of resources
- Social harmony and cooperation

Advantages

- Reduces poverty and discrimination
- Creates social peace and unity
- Increases opportunities for all people

Challenges

- Difficult to achieve complete equality
- Economic differences may still exist
- Requires strong laws and public awareness

Rank Society

A rank society is a type of society where people are divided into different social levels or ranks based on status, family background, power, wealth, or occupation.

- Society is organized in a hierarchy.
- Some groups have higher social status than others.
- People receive respect and privileges according to their rank.
- Social inequality is common.
- Movement from one rank to another may be limited.

Features

- Presence of upper, middle, and lower classes
- Unequal distribution of power and resources
- Social status affects lifestyle and opportunities

Examples

- Feudal societies
- Caste-based societies
- Monarchies with nobles and common people
- Advantages
- Clear social organization
- Stability in traditional systems

Disadvantages

- Discrimination and inequality
- Limited social mobility
- Can create conflict between classes

Division of Labour

Division of labour means dividing work into different tasks and assigning each task to different people according to their skills and abilities.

Features

- Work is split into smaller tasks.
- Each worker specializes in one task.
- Increases efficiency and productivity.
- Common in factories, industries, and organizations.

Advantages

- Saves time

- Improves skill and expertise
- Increases production
- Reduces workload for individuals

Disadvantages

- Repetitive work may cause boredom
- Workers may lose overall knowledge of production
- Too much specialization can reduce creativity

Examples

In a garment factory, different workers cut cloth, sew clothes, and package products.
In hospitals, doctors, nurses, and technicians perform different duties.

Class Society

A class society is a society where people are divided into social classes mainly based on wealth, income, education, and occupation.

Features

- Society is divided into upper, middle, and lower classes.
- Social status depends on economic position.
- People may move from one class to another through education or hard work.
- Unequal distribution of wealth and opportunities exists.

Types of Classes

- Upper Class – wealthy and powerful people
- Middle Class – professionals, teachers, business people
- Lower Class – low-income workers and poor people

Advantages

- Encourages competition and hard work
- Provides chances for social mobility
- Disadvantages
- Creates inequality between rich and poor
- May lead to social conflict and discrimination

Examples

Modern industrial and capitalist societies are examples of class societies.

Caste Society in Bangladesh

A caste society is a social system where people are divided into groups by birth, and social status is usually fixed.

Caste Society in Bangladesh

Bangladesh is mainly a Muslim-majority country, so the caste system is not as strong as in some neighboring countries.

However, caste-like divisions exist among some Hindu communities.

Certain groups traditionally perform specific occupations such as fishing, cleaning, or pottery.

Lower-caste groups may face social discrimination and limited opportunities.

Features

- Social status determined by birth
- Traditional occupations passed from generation to generation
- Restrictions in marriage and social interaction in some communities

Problems

- Social inequality
- Discrimination and exclusion
- Limited access to education and jobs for lower groups
- Present Situation
- Modern education, urbanization, and laws are reducing caste discrimination.
- Human rights organizations and the government promote equality and social justice in Bangladesh.

Sociology and Critical Race

Sociology and Critical Race Theory often examine how racism and inequality are connected.

Racism is discrimination, prejudice, or unequal treatment based on race or ethnicity. It can happen at different levels:

Individual racism — personal beliefs, insults, stereotypes, or discriminatory actions.

Institutional racism — policies or systems in schools, workplaces, healthcare, housing, or policing that create unequal outcomes.

Structural racism — broader historical and social patterns that keep inequalities in place over generations.

Inequality refers to unfair differences in opportunities, wealth, education, healthcare, political power, or social treatment between groups.

These two issues are closely linked because racism often produces or reinforces inequality.

Examples include:

Unequal access to quality education

Employment discrimination

Differences in income and wealth
Unequal healthcare treatment
Housing segregation
Bias in criminal justice systems

Historically, events such as Transatlantic Slave Trade, Apartheid, and Jim Crow laws created long-term social and economic inequalities that still affect societies today.

Many movements have challenged racism and inequality, including the Civil Rights Movement and organizations such as Black Lives Matter.

Ways societies try to reduce racism and inequality include:

1. Equal rights laws
2. Anti-discrimination policies
3. Better access to education and healthcare
4. Economic opportunities
5. Representation in leadership and media
6. Public awareness and dialogue

The dynamics of caste

The dynamics of caste refers to how caste systems operate, change, and influence society over time. Caste is a form of social stratification where people are grouped by birth, occupation, social status, and traditional roles. It has been especially significant in India and parts of South Asia.

Main Features of Caste Dynamics

1. Social Hierarchy

Caste creates a ranked social order. Traditionally, society was divided into groups such as:

1. Brahmins (priests and scholars)
2. Kshatriyas (warriors and rulers)
3. Vaishyas (traders)
4. Shudras (workers)

Outside this hierarchy were groups historically treated as “untouchables,” now commonly referred to as Dalits.

2. Birth-Based Status

A person’s caste is generally determined by birth and traditionally cannot easily be changed. This affects:

1. Marriage
2. Occupation
3. Social interactions
4. Religious practices

3. Endogamy

People are often expected to marry within their own caste. This helps maintain caste boundaries across generations.

4. Occupational Roles

Historically, occupations were linked to caste groups. Although modernization has weakened this connection, caste can still influence employment opportunities and social mobility.

5. Power and Inequality

Caste dynamics involve unequal access to:

1. Education
2. Wealth
3. Land ownership
4. Political influence
5. Social respect
6. Lower caste groups have historically faced discrimination and exclusion.

6. Social Mobility and Change

Modern education, urbanization, industrialization, and democratic politics have changed caste relations. Some important developments include:

1. Reservation or affirmative action policies
2. Increased political participation of lower castes
3. Social reform movements
4. Legal protection against discrimination

7. Caste and Politics

In many regions, caste influences voting patterns, political alliances, and leadership. Political parties may organize support around caste identities.

8. Caste in Contemporary Society

Even with legal equality, caste can still affect:

1. Access to opportunities
2. Social networks
3. Marriage choices
4. Economic conditions
5. At the same time, globalization, migration, and technology are reshaping traditional caste boundaries.